SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

ETHICAL DILEMMAS AND COPING MECHANISMS FACED BY YOUNG ENTREPRENEURS

A Thesis Presented To
The Faculty of
College of Business Management

In Partial Requirements for the Degree
BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN BUSINESS ADMNISTRATION

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NOVEMBER 2025

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SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
College Of Business Management

CERTIFICATE OF RESEARCH APPROVAL

This thesis entitled **"ETHICAL DILEMMAS AND COPING MECHANISMS FACED BY YOUNG ENTREPRENEURS"** presented and submitted by James Clarence P. Gonzales, Eurica Faye M. Bual, Jolian E. Mangubat, Melody Lira L. Panuncio, Ronald Kent P. Pasco, and Yves Jericho A. Silverio in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Bachelor of Science in Business Administration Major in Financial Management is hereby accepted and recommended for Oral Examination.

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Ethical dilemmas are situations in which people or organizations must choose between good and evil, and sometimes these choices are tough when ethical values or principles clash. In business, ethical behavior is recognized by compliance with society's needs, moral standards, and laws that stand for accountable corporate activity. Nevertheless, the spiritual aspect of culture has the greatest impact on entrepreneurs' morale. According to Seema Bhakuni (2025) Ethical dilemmas in business can arise in numerous backgrounds, including financial organization, employee relationships, customer communications, and acquiescence with regulatory values.

The development plans of many developing countries, including Malaysia, emphasize young entrepreneurship because youth hold great potential to contribute to social, economic, and political progress. Governments widely recognize entrepreneurship as essential for fostering prosperity and regional growth, especially among the young. Research has focused on challenges faced by new business owners, as many small ventures struggle to survive. Young entrepreneurs often encounter major obstacles such as lack of mentors, management skills, financial resources, and funding access. Financial constraints, in particular, can lead to business failure due to undercapitalization Yuhanis Mohamed Noor et al. (2021).

According to Amanda Biggs et al. (2024), coping involves efforts to address personal and interpersonal problems and reduce stress. Coping strategies fall into two main types: problem-based coping, which aims to solve or reduce the stressful situation, and emotion-based coping, which focuses on managing the emotional impact of stress.

Young entrepreneurs in the Philippines often face tough ethical challenges in running their businesses. Ignacio (2023) found that only a few Filipino small business owners show "moral imagination"—the ability to consider all stakeholders, foresee long-term impacts, and create ethical solutions. Without this, many decisions focus narrowly on personal gain rather than the wider social effects. For young founders still shaping their identity, this creates conflicts between profit and doing what's right.

In the 2024 study "Impact of Social Media Marketing on Consumers in Philippines" by Alyssa Marie which implicitly refers to small and medium businesses (SMEs), retailers, and online-based firms that use social media platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter to reach customers the author argues that social media marketing significantly changes how Filipino consumers communicate with brands. Through personalized content, influencer endorsements, and interactive exchanges (comments, reviews, direct messages), these businesses can create a sense of closeness and trust with customers: many Filipinos report being swayed by this kind of engagement when deciding to purchase.

Jimenez et al. (2022) found that despite financial hardships, some young Filipino entrepreneurs in MSMEs chose to prioritize the well-being of employees, customers, and communities over short-term profits. They showed solidarity by innovating and using limited resources to support others, even at risk to their own business stability. This highlights the tension young founders face between social responsibility and financial survival, a challenge that experienced entrepreneurs may handle more easily.

This research aims to investigate the ethical issues encountered by young entrepreneurs in Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, and the actions they take to resolve them. It will center on the problems and issues, namely: Financial Organization Dilemmas, Employee Relationship Dilemmas, Customer Communication Dilemmas, and Acquiescence with Regulatory

Value Dilemmas in business practices. The objective of the research is to learn about the ethical dilemmas frequently faced by young entrepreneurs and their coping strategies. The outcome will be a map that guides responsible, ethical entrepreneurship among the younger generation of business owners.

The significance of it in the department is that the study will be useful as it provides valuable insights into the ethical challenges and coping strategies of young entrepreneur in Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. The findings can help the department design training programs, seminars and courses that strengthen students understanding of business ethics and decision making. It can also serve as a reference for future researchers on entrepreneurship development and ethical practices.

The research is essential because it will benefit various categories of people involved. For upcoming young entrepreneurs, it will be a valuable source of knowledge about typical ethical problems and ways to solve them. They can develop tactics to address moral dilemmas and make their enterprises more ethical and stronger by learning from their counterparts' experiences. The research will lead to the sharing of experiences among young entrepreneurs, and thus, learning, supporting, and community feeling will be in place.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Ethical Dilemmas

Young entrepreneurs frequently face ethical dilemmas in their business ventures because the pressures of growth, competition, and limited resources can create situations where personal or organizational values are challenged. In the study of Daradkeh (2023) highlights that these dilemmas arise from conflicts between short-term financial gains and long-term ethical responsibilities. For young entrepreneurs, who often lack experience and structured ethical guidance, navigating these challenges can be particularly difficult, potentially affecting both trust and the sustainability of their businesses Daradkeh (2023).

Young entrepreneurs often face tough ethical challenges because they work under pressures like limited resources, strong competition, and the need to gain trust. These pressures sometimes push them to make decisions that conflict with their personal and business values. According to Uriarte et al. (2024), these challenges come not just from their choices but also from external factors such as societal expectations, investor demands, and laws. Young and first-time entrepreneurs usually lack experience and clear moral frameworks, making it harder for them to balance their growth goals with their responsibilities to stakeholders and society.

Studies suggest that ethical training, mentorship, and supportive communities can help these young founders recognize and handle ethical issues better, leading to more responsible business growth (Ince, 2025).

Fatmawati et al. (2024) add that because startups operate in competitive and changing environments, founders struggle between keeping ethical standards and doing whatever it takes to survive and grow. Cordasco (2023) highlights that for young entrepreneurs, businesses are more than money-making projects—they reflect personal values and beliefs. So, external pressures like investors can create conflicts when they clash with these values.

In crisis situations, like the COVID-19 pandemic in the Philippines, young entrepreneurs struggled to balance saving their companies and caring for employees, facing tough choices such as layoffs versus sacrificing profits, which affects their sense of duty and solidarity (Pabalan & Macaraan, 2021).

Finally, Alzate et al. (2024) note that young social entrepreneurs constantly wrestle with balancing their mission-driven goals against economic needs, deciding when to put social impact ahead of profit and how to manage limited resources fairly.

Financial Organization Dilemmas

Young entrepreneurs often face financial difficulties because they usually lack basic financial knowledge. Aristei et al. (2024) found that this lack of financial literacy makes young entrepreneurs hesitant to apply for business loans, fearing rejection or high application costs. For example, among Italian micro-enterprises, those with weaker financial knowledge are more likely to avoid seeking external funding, even though credit could help their businesses grow.

Start-ups tend to spend more money than they earn due to large investments in technology, marketing, and working capital, which often exceed income from operations. Jean-Michael Sahut et al. (2021) explain that these cash shortages can lead to default and bankruptcy if financial resources run out. Despite these risks, entrepreneurs often invest substantial money, time, and energy into their ventures, developing close ties that make exiting a major life event (Jenkins & Byrne, 2020; Kleine et al., 2023; Lee et al., 2022). Financial stress arises from low working capital, lack of collateral for bank loans, and pressures to pay bills, salaries, rent, and taxes (Gautam & Gautam, 2023; Anne-Kathrin Kleine et al., 2024).

In Tanzania, Isaga (2025) found that limited access to traditional banks forces many young entrepreneurs to turn to crowd lending platforms, but high interest rates and transaction fees on these platforms often reduce their benefits. Similarly, Ferdousi et al. (2022) show that in

Bangladesh, social business funds—which offer more flexible financing—significantly raise incomes for micro-entrepreneurs. However, these funds are not yet widespread, and without stronger policy support, many young founders continue to rely on expensive credit or informal loans, limiting their ability to grow sustainably.

Rashid et al. (2025) report that in Pakistan, limited capital access severely restricts young entrepreneurs, as many lack collateral or credit history needed to secure financing. This limits their ability to invest in innovation and infrastructure, hampering growth and economic contribution. Bernardino and Santos (2020) highlight that many young founders have only moderate knowledge of alternative funding methods like crowdfunding. Their unfamiliarity prevents them from accessing equity or lending-based crowdfunding options that could help overcome traditional financing barriers.

Overall, financial challenges cause major stress for young entrepreneurs, forcing tough choices such as prioritizing short-term profits over long-term sustainability or employee welfare. Li et al. (2022) found that perceived financial threats increase anxiety and shape coping strategies. Entrepreneurs with strong financial management skills tend to use problem-focused approaches like budgeting, seeking loans, or adjusting business models to navigate financial pressures and maintain stability.

Employee Relationship Dilemmas

In the study by Dr. B. Arul Senthil (2021) investigates the relationship between employee well-being and organizational performance, focusing on the manufacturing sector in Bangalore. It highlights that employee well-being initiatives significantly influence organizational effectiveness and employee motivation. The research utilizes empirical methods, collecting primary data through questionnaires from 100 manufacturing employees. Findings indicate that well-being not only impacts performance but also shapes employee behavior and attitudes toward their

work environment. However, the study acknowledges limitations, including respondent reluctance and a narrow geographic and sectoral focus. Its key contribution lies in demonstrating how meeting employee expectations regarding well-being can enhance workplace performance.

Young entrepreneurs face employee dilemmas such as lack of training due to tight budgets, difficulty delegating tasks due to control issues, and challenges in finding and retaining talented employees who can help grow the company. Startups often struggle to compete with bigger companies offering higher salaries but may attract employees through perks like equity, flexible work, remote options, and positive work culture. Managing employee issues like job-hopping, poor attitudes, lack of motivation, and emotional instability, especially among young staff, is also a significant dilemma. Communication, active listening, and career development are key strategies used to address employee management challenges. (Noor, Y.M., & Ayob, A.H. (2021).

Young entrepreneurs often face serious employee related challenges because Domurath et al. (2023) found that in young ventures, employees' intent to leave the firm grows over time particularly when hires have little prior start-up experience and the business is experiencing low growth. For a young founder managing a nascent enterprise, high turnover intent translates into increased risk of losing key talent, disrupting workflow, and needing to allocate scarce resources toward recruiting and retraining instead of innovation or expansion, making people management a substantial barrier in early-stage business growth.

A study of Noor and Ayub (2021), they found that many young entrepreneurs in Malaysia face a serious employee management challenge. Many struggle to retain their workforce, especially when many of their employees are young workers who frequently job-hop, lack commitment, or exhibit unstable emotions. Because of these staffing issues, young founders often have to invest considerable time in communication, career development, and training to

maintain a stable and motivated team, otherwise their business growth is undermined by constant turnover and low employee morale.

Ahmed and Ahmed (2021) identified young entrepreneurs in Ethiopia faces serious challenges in managing employees and gaining support because they have limited access to business assistance and support as a major constraint for youth-led micro and small enterprises. This lack of structured support means young founders often struggle to recruit, train, and retain employees, which undermines their capacity to sustain and scale their ventures.

One area particularly fraught with ethical challenges is the management of human resources and employees. Entrepreneurs face dilemmas such as maintaining fairness in hiring and compensation, managing conflicts among employees, and balancing the interests of various stakeholders while fostering organizational loyalty (Forbes, 2021). Young entrepreneurs often struggle with these HR issues because their nascent ventures may lack formalized policies or comprehensive compliance mechanisms (Santa Clara University, n.d.).

Customer Communication Dilemmas

Young entrepreneurs often struggle with customer-focused challenges because Al-Fattal (2025) found that many aspiring founders in his study of business students are uncertain about customer identification and engagement, they don't always know exactly who their future customers are, how to reach them, or how to build real relationships. Because of this uncertainty, these young entrepreneurs may misdirect their limited marketing resources or fail to create messaging that resonates, making it harder to attract and retain customers, which in turn undermines their business's ability to gain traction and grow sustainably.

Customer-related pressures significantly influence how young entrepreneurs navigate ethical dilemmas and coping strategies. Changes in customer demands, expectations, or behaviors can create both operational stress and moral tension, especially when entrepreneurs

must decide between satisfying customers and maintaining ethical business practices. According to Coughlan and Black (2023), entrepreneurs often face situations where meeting customer demands may conflict with product quality, fair pricing, or sustainability goals, requiring careful ethical evaluation. In the local Philippine context, Andal et al. (2021) found that MSME owners adapted to customer pressures during crises by leveraging digital platforms, modifying products or services, and improving communication with clients. These strategies not only addressed customer needs but also helped entrepreneurs manage stress and maintain ethical standards.

Young entrepreneurs face significant customer related dilemmas when running their businesses because the shift to digital platforms during the pandemic brought a host of market problems: Cueto et al. (2022) found that many youth-led MSMEs in the Philippines struggled with market-related problems in digital platforms, including difficulty in reaching customers online, fierce competition for attention, and inconsistent demand from shifting consumer behavior. These issues meant that younger founders who often lack established brands, large customer networks, or deep marketing experience had to spend disproportionate time and resources just to attract and retain customers instead of focusing on innovation or growth. Thus, customer acquisition and engagement emerge as serious obstacles for young entrepreneurs, because without a stable, loyal customer base their business viability becomes precarious.

Acquiescence with Regulatory Values Dilemmas

The burden of regulatory compliance represents a serious dilemma for young entrepreneurs according to Francisco et al. (2022), each additional working day spent dealing with government regulations reduces the probability of sales and workforce growth among SMEs and this negative effect is significantly larger for younger firms, whose lack of experience and limited resources force them to spend even more time on bureaucratic red tape. This regulatory burden is especially problematic for young business owners because it diverts short supply

resources, both time and money, away from value creating activities, such as expanding operations or innovating, and toward compliance tasks that don't directly contribute to growth.

According to Tambe et al. (2022) Young entrepreneurs often struggle with regulatory dilemmas because the burdens imposed by taxes, bureaucracy, labor laws, and even corruption significantly hamper small business growth. As observed by the author of SMEs in Polokwane Township. These regulatory pressures force emerging business owners to divert limited resources not just money, but time and energy, away from innovation or expansion, making it much harder for them to scale up or even sustain their enterprises.

A study of Safiullah (2025) The core problem for young entrepreneurs lies in the "Regulatory Dilemma," which is the pervasive challenge of navigating intricate government policy that struggles to keep pace with rapid business innovation, forcing founders to choose between swift market entry and meticulous, resource-intensive compliance with complex, overlapping, and constantly evolving laws. The Regulatory Dilemma is a significant external hurdle for young entrepreneurs, primarily because the complexity of legal and regulatory challenges adds an enormous, unexpected layer of difficulty to the already intense journey of starting a business, forcing them to spend critical time and limited resources deciphering opaque compliance requirements rather than focusing on innovation and growth (Sait & Kasmir, 2023).

According to Malenya et al. (2025) The problem of Regulatory Dilemmas is a persistent obstacle because the required legal framework, or regulatory complexities, is often a significant structural barrier that hampers the scalability and sustainability of young entrepreneurs' ventures, forcing them to spend vital energy on compliance instead of focusing on business growth and job creation.

Coping Mechanism

Coping strategies are important for handling stress, unethical behavior, and workforce diversity challenges. Amanda Biggs et al. (2024) describe coping as efforts to solve personal and social problems and reduce stress caused by difficult situations. There are two main types of coping: problem-based coping, which focuses on actions to change or fix stressful situations, and emotion-based coping, which manages feelings and emotional responses to stress.

Silva et al. (2023) found that startups dealt with the pandemic by adopting flexible coping strategies such as using digital technologies, keeping strong relationships with customers and stakeholders, and staying adaptable in their operations. These strategies are especially important for young entrepreneurs, who often have less experience and fewer safety nets. By being agile and resilient, they can respond quickly to unexpected problems and make careful, ethical decisions, helping them survive disruptions and build sustainable businesses.

Hwang (2024) showed that small and medium-sized enterprise (SME) owners cope with economic uncertainty through cost control, reallocating resources, digital innovation, and promoting team unity. For young entrepreneurs, emotional resilience and flexible leadership are key to handling financial instability and the ethical pressures that come with business risks.

Li (2024) highlights that young entrepreneurs often face financial challenges and cope by improving financial intelligence. This includes improving internal information quality, automating fund-flow transparency, and optimizing financial management systems. These data-driven and process-focused strategies help reduce information gaps and increase creditworthiness, which is crucial for those with limited collateral or credit history. For young entrepreneurs who have limited resources and face high risk, these strategies are essential to survive and handle both financial and ethical challenges.

Finally, Thompson et al. (2020) emphasize that entrepreneurship is stressful, especially for young founders facing uncertainty and pressure. They use emotion-focused coping like changing how they view problems, seeking support from others, and taking breaks to manage stress. This is an active, strategic way to maintain motivation, resilience, and strong performance despite challenges.

Problem-focused Coping

The problem-focused coping strategies by developing schedules to specifically manage their work and family responsibilities or get support from their family members or childminder to assist which diminish stress and burnout, resulting in improved subjective well-being. Obey Dzamonda et al. (2025)

Problem-focused coping is when entrepreneurs actively tackle challenges by finding solutions, planning, and making changes to handle stress. This approach is especially important for young entrepreneurs dealing with ethical issues, financial pressure, or business uncertainty because it focuses on practical problem-solving instead of just reacting emotionally. Thompson et al. (2020) found that entrepreneurs using problem-focused coping can better adjust their goals, plan ahead, and take clear actions to solve business and ethical problems. Likewise, Li et al. (2022) showed that being proactive with resource management, planning, and seeking help helps reduce the negative effects of threats on performance and decision-making.

In the local Philippine context, Andal et al. (2021) observed that MSME owners applied problem-focused coping during crises by restructuring operations, adopting digital tools, and innovating product lines, which helped maintain business continuity while upholding ethical standards. These findings demonstrate that problem-focused coping enables young entrepreneurs to navigate complex situations methodically, balancing ethical considerations with business objectives, and reinforcing resilience in the face of uncertainty. Understanding this

coping strategy is crucial for research on ethical dilemmas, as it highlights how entrepreneurs actively manage both moral and operational challenges rather than simply reacting emotionally.

According to Nur Eva et al. (2024) states that the level of psychological well-being is caused by factors such as coping strategies or the ability to deal with pressure which is divided into two types and one of them is problem-focused coping. Problem-focused coping is a form of stress resolution that focuses on the problem to find information and manage situations or relationships with others.

Emotion-focused Coping

Entrepreneurship is commonly seen as an emotional 'rollercoaster ride' characterized by heightened emotions. To date, research on emotions in entrepreneurship has predominantly focused on the experience of either positive or negative emotions, their antecedents (e.g. stress, uncertainty, and success), and their consequences on entrepreneurial performance and well-being, which is also reflected by existing systematic reviews on emotions in the entrepreneurial context. However, emotions are neither static nor only positive or negative; rather, emotions can be managed to achieve certain goals Lynn Schmodde et al. (2024).

Also, a study of Nikolaev et al. (2024) stipulate that Emotion-focused coping strategies focus on reducing stressful situations by using emotional responses such as venting, denial, behavioral disengagement, meditation, religion and exercising, anger, or self-preoccupation.

In addition, according to Pathak and Goltz (2021), entrepreneurs with higher emotional intelligence are more likely to engage in strategies such as reframing stressful situations, seeking emotional reassurance, and adopting optimism to protect their psychological well-being amidst demanding business conditions. As a result, emotion-focused coping becomes a vital mechanism for young business owners as they navigate the complexities and emotional demands of entrepreneurship.

Lastly, the study by Ding et al. (2021) showed that emotion-focused coping can reduce psychological distress by lowering an individual's perceived stress, meaning that managing one's emotions becomes an essential protective strategy when facing uncontrollable pressures. Applying these findings to entrepreneurship, young business owners may rely on emotional regulation, acceptance, or reframing their thoughts to maintain stability and prevent stress from overwhelming their decision-making. Thus, emotion-focused coping becomes not just a reaction, but a practical way for young entrepreneurs to stay resilient when external business conditions feel overwhelming (Ding et al., 2021).

Age

According to Zelekha & Kavé (2022), Young entrepreneurs frequently encounter age related business challenges because the study finds that entrepreneurial tendency declines with age those younger than 50 are more inclined toward starting new ventures, while the negative effect of age weakens and almost disappears after age 50. This suggests that starting young comes with both an advantage and a dilemma. Younger founders may have more drive and entrepreneurial inclination, yet they often lack the experience, networks or resources that older individuals have built making it harder for them to convert that tendency into sustainable business success.

Younger founders appear strongly disadvantaged in their tendency to produce the highest-growth companies. Below age 25, founders appear to do badly (or rather, do well extremely rarely), but there is a sharp increase in performance at age 25. Between ages 25 and 35, performance seems flat. Starting after age 35, there is increased success probabilities. Another large surge in performance comes at age 46 and is sustained toward age 60 Michael Matheson Miller (2020). The entrepreneurial spirit can be found at all life stages, from kids to grown-ups, and it is a never-ending process of teaching and learning for those involved. Kids'

involvement in business gives them the chance to learn basic skills, encourages the development of characteristics like leadership, and increases their adaptability (Aashiem, 2024).

In the case of Suman Sah (2023) Young entrepreneurs under the age of 35 represent a growing and important segment of the entrepreneurial community. According to recent reports, more than half of the world's population is under the age of 30, and this demographic group is expected to make up a significant portion of the workforce and consumer market in the coming years. Understanding the factors that contribute to young entrepreneurs' success is crucial to fostering entrepreneurship and economic growth.

In a 2020 study by Brieger, Bäro, Criaco, they found a found a U-shaped relationship between an entrepreneur's age and their social value creation goals, meaning that younger (and older) entrepreneurs tend to prioritize social objectives more, while middle aged entrepreneurs focus more on purely economic gains. Younger founders might struggle to balance their altruistic drive with the economic pressures of business, especially in institutional contexts that don't fully support social-value goals.

Young entrepreneurs in Pakistan face serious age-related business challenges, Asad (2022) found that younger founders often struggle with a lack of experience, limited awareness of supportive business-political policies, and societal perceptions that question their capabilities simply because of their age. These barriers compounded by financial dependency, weak family support, and cultural resistance make it difficult for youth to sustain their startups, undermining their confidence to make important business decisions.

According to Smail et al, (2022) Young entrepreneurs often face age-related dilemmas in business because, in their study of Emirati university students, the authors found that they are relatively risk averse, this hesitation is driven by low self-efficacy, fear of failure, perceived institutional barriers, and insufficient government support. Because of their youth, these aspiring

founders may lack the confidence, networks, or backing to absorb risk, making them more cautious and less likely to take the bold steps that entrepreneurship often requires.

Lastly, a study of Yuan et al. (2022) Young entrepreneurs are often confronted with age-linked business obstacles, especially when deciding to return to their hometowns. The authors found that many youths perceive significant barriers such as lagging infrastructure, inadequate entrepreneurial experience, and limited funding- that discourage them from launching ventures in rural areas. These institutional and environmental challenges make it difficult for young people to leverage their education and ambition, forcing them to rely heavily on mentorship, shared experience, and policy support to realize their entrepreneurial dreams.

Sex

In the study Ivan Szabvari “Physiology and Behavior” (2023) an overview of Sex refers to the biological differences between males and females. Two distinct sexes- males and females are determined by sex chromosomes and genes that form certain gonads, internal and external genitalia, and physiological hormones. Another crucial aspect that contributes to phenotypical sexual differences is epigenetics

According to the edition of the McKinsey and Company et al. (2024) report, distinguishing between male and female participation in business matters is crucial because the early leadership pipeline is biased, mostly men dominate manager-level roles, which means there are fewer women available to rise into senior position, not only perpetuates sex imbalances but also weakens organizational talent flows and diversity of perspective.

However, the authors found that, even among equally educated students, men reported significantly higher entrepreneurial intentions than women, and that women's generally lower risk-taking tendency and weaker entrepreneurial self-identity help explain part of this gap (Schmitt-Rodermund et al., 2025).

Educational Attainment

In today's fast-changing, connected world, education plays a vital role in shaping effective business management. Santos (2022) explained that education helps entrepreneurs understand how to handle challenges, make informed decisions, and apply effective business strategies. Brown and Souto-Otero (2020) also noted that education serves as a foundation for business success, equipping individuals with the knowledge and confidence to run enterprises efficiently.

In the study Education and entrepreneur: how learning drive business success (2024) states Entrepreneurship has long been celebrated as the realm of innovation, risk-taking, and visionary leadership. While many successful entrepreneurs are often perceived as natural-born leaders, education plays a far more crucial role in building the foundation for long-term success than is sometimes acknowledged. A solid educational background empowers entrepreneurs with the knowledge, tools, and networks to transform ideas into thriving businesses, enabling them to navigate the complexities of today’s rapidly evolving marketplace. Education is the foundation upon which entrepreneurs can build successful ventures. It provides them with essential business skills like financial literacy, marketing strategies, and leadership acumen.

However, Joseph et al. (2022) argued that education alone is not enough. Personal factors such as attitude, thinking ability, behavior, and prior experience also influence how entrepreneurs make decisions and manage their businesses. This shows that both education and personal traits contribute to a firm's success.

Business Experience

It is good to be excited about launching a new venture, but experienced candidates know that more than 90% of new businesses fail. This is because most new business owners need to gain the right business knowledge. You may be an expert in your art, but not in managing books,

logistics, people, technology, and compliance. You may not be able to predict risks for your business from your current level of knowledge, Robin Waite (2025).

The number of years a company has been in operation significantly impacts its business performance, depending on its stage of development. In the early stages, young companies often leverage modern technology, flexible business models, and lower costs to achieve rapid growth. However, they may struggle with credibility issues, limited capital, and an unstable customer base, making them more vulnerable to market fluctuations. In contrast, well-established companies tend to have strong financial foundations, diversified service offerings, and effective risk management systems, allowing them to maintain stability even in volatile market conditions. Thus, the number of years a company has been in operation not only influences profitability but also shapes its strategic development at different stages. The number of years of operation (NYO) is represented by a categorical variable. Vietnamese commercial banks are classified into five groups based on their years of operation 0-5 years, 5-10 years, 10-15 years, 15-20 years and 20-25 years Ngan Thi Nguyen et al. (2025).

Also, Calvino et al. (2022) reported a robust correlation between a company's age and its growth and stability. Aged companies are likely to enjoy the advantages of very tight relationships and the continuity of their operations. Still, at the same time, they might face the downside of being slow to respond to an ever-changing market. On the other hand, Kanama et al. (2025) found that age diversity among founding team members can accelerate a startup's growth, as different age groups contribute distinct viewpoints and experiences.

The study of Handwerker and Moriera (2021), the lifespan of business ventures is characterized by changes. They found that experience automatically leads companies to be more organized, less rigid, and, consequently, more capable of acquiring new skills, which, in turn, translates into better performance and greater adaptability of firms in the market. Every business

has its challenges, and the background of the entrepreneurs matters less, since starting and running a business is not a simple task. Growing evidence suggests that it is a normal process for any novel entrepreneurs to face challenges or obstacles during the early stage of establishing new ventures Yuhanis Mohamed Noor et al. (2021).

1.3 Theoretical Framework

The *Rest's four component model theory* by American psychologist James Rest 1980s–1990s has provided legal ethics scholarship with a theoretical model for understanding – and then improving – moral action. Rest's model provides a framework for analyzing ethical dilemmas by pinpointing weak or absent components, guiding interventions to strengthen them, and highlighting that ethical behavior requires the full integration of all four processes. The Rest's four component model theory identifies four essential psychological processes for ethical behavior: moral sensitivity (recognizing ethical dimensions), moral judgement (determining right actions), moral motivation (prioritizing moral values), and moral character (having the strength to act morally). Absence of any element can lead to ethical lapses, as illustrated by the potential failure to recognize moral issues even with moral courage.

The transactional model of stress and coping, developed by Richard S. Lazarus and Susan Folkman in 1984, emphasizes the subjective experience of stress and coping mechanisms. It categorizes coping strategies into two types: problem-focused coping, which directly addresses stressors, and emotion-focused coping, which alleviates emotional distress. The model underscores the evolving nature of coping responses as individuals reappraise their situations, reflecting the dynamic process of stress management. Lazarus and Folkman's stress and coping model (1984) adds to Rest's moral model by showing how people think about stressful situations and pick ways to deal with them—either by solving the problem or easing their feelings. Together, the two models explain how stress can affect moral awareness, judgment, motivation, and character, and how coping can help or hurt moral choices. This combined view gives a clearer picture of how stress shapes moral behavior and points to ways to support people with ethical and emotional guidance. Ultimately, the transactional model illustrates how cognitive

evaluations shape emotional responses and influence behavior, offering valuable insights into the complexities of stress and coping mechanisms across diverse contexts.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

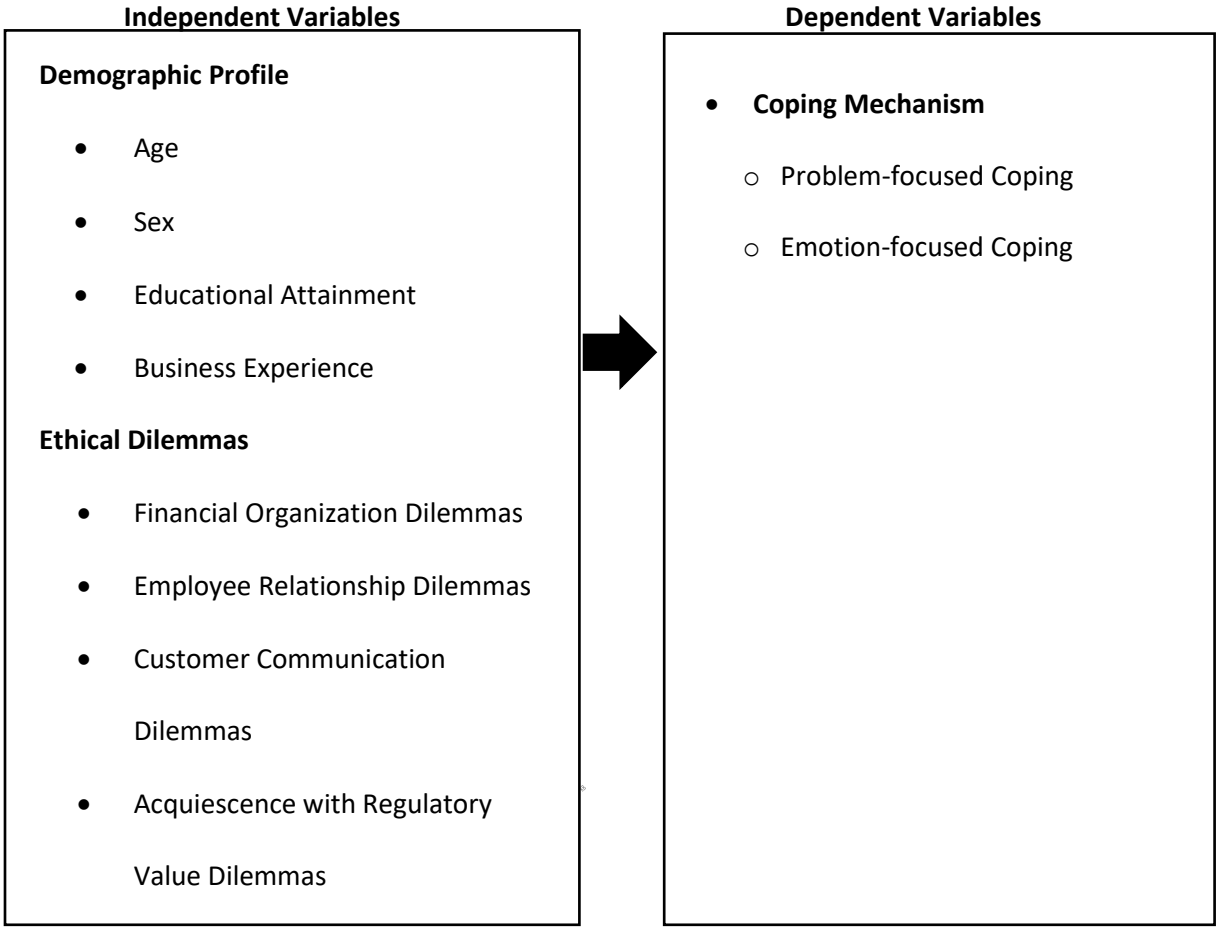


Figure 1: Schematic diagram of the interplay between the independent and dependent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem

This study determines the ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms faced by Young Entrepreneurs.

Specifically, it will answer the following questions:

1. What is the profile of the respondents in terms of:

    1.1 Age;

    1.2 Sex;

    1.3 Educational Attainment; and

    1.4 Business Experience?

2. To what extent are ethical dilemmas faced by young entrepreneurs related to:

    2.1 Financial Organization Dilemmas;

    2.2 Employee Relationship Dilemmas;

    2.3 Customer Communication Dilemmas; and

    2.4 Acquiescence with Regulatory Value Dilemmas?

3. To what extent are coping mechanism is used by young entrepreneurs consisting of:

    3.1 Problem-focused Coping; and

    3.2 Emotion-focused Coping?

4. Is there a significant relationship between demographic profile and ethical dilemmas faced by young entrepreneurs?

5. Is there a significant relationship between ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms faced by young entrepreneurs?

Hypothesis

H_0: There is no significant relationship between ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms faced by young entrepreneurs.

1.6 Scope and Limitations

Scope and Limitations

This study will assess the ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms among young entrepreneurs who operate businesses such as retail shops such as: convenience store, discount store and grocery store, between six months and one year in the municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. The focus of this study is to analyze the ethical dilemmas young entrepreneurs face in their daily operations and to explore the coping mechanisms they use to address them. To collect the data and ensure accurate responses and avoid biases. The researchers will ask respondents a few questions through interviews and questionnaires they prepared, which will be conducted in person.

This study is limited to young entrepreneurs (18–35 years old) who own and manage businesses in the municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. Young entrepreneurs that do not belong to these municipalities are excluded from this study. The results of this study may not be generalized to all young entrepreneurs in Agusan del Norte.

1.7 Definition of Terms

For better understanding, the following terms are operationally defined as follows:

Acquiescence. Refers to Compliance.

Age. Referring to the length of time a young entrepreneur has existed.

Business Experience. Relates to years of experience in business.

Communication. The process of exchanging of information between customers, employees, and young entrepreneurs.

Coping Mechanism. A strategy or behavior a young entrepreneurs use to manage challenges.

Customer. A person or organization who buys goods and services from young entrepreneurs.

Educational Attainment. It refers to the highest level of education an owner has completed.

Employee. An individual who works under supervision or control of an employer.

Emotion-focused Coping. Refers to how young entrepreneurs manage their feelings when faced with ethical dilemmas.

Ethical Dilemmas. It refers to a situation in which a young entrepreneurs must choose between two or more conflicting moral principles or values.

Financial. Relates to the problem of money in the company or the owner itself.

Organization. A company or business owned by the owner.

Problem-focused Coping. Refers to how young entrepreneurs take direct action to solve or reduce the ethical dilemmas they face.

Regulatory. Refers to laws, guidelines, and rules set by the government which are followed by the young entrepreneurs.

Relationship. A connection between customers, employees, and young entrepreneurs.

Retail store. The focus business for our respondents.

Sex. Refers to the identity of young entrepreneurs, whether male or female.

Values. Refers to young entrepreneur's principle.

Young Entrepreneurs. Refers to individuals aged 18-35 who are actively engaged in business activities within the selected municipalities.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

This chapter discusses the study's research design, research locale, research respondents, research instruments, research ethical standards, data-gathering procedures, and statistical treatment.

2.1 Research Design

This research study will use mixed-method approach research combines both inductive and deductive reasoning within a single study framework. It typically uses quantitative methods (deductive) to test these ideas or hypotheses and qualitative methods (inductive) to generate new ideas or theories from data. This approach allows researchers to use the strengths of both methodologies to better understand complex phenomena. The researchers will use mixed methods in this study because they provide a more complete, robust, and varied understanding of the complex issue of ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms among young entrepreneurs than a single method could offer. The research design suits the study, providing information and guiding the young entrepreneur in addressing their ethical dilemmas and coping with them.

2.2 Research Locale

The study will be conducted in the municipalities of Buenavista and Carmen in the province of Agusan del Norte, located in the Northeastern portion of Mindanao Island. These areas were chosen as the research sites because they include youth entrepreneurs aged 18-35 who manage the new businesses at six (6) months to one (1) year and benefit from programs of the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) and Negosyo Centers. This locale serves as a setting for examining the opportunities available to young entrepreneurs and for addressing ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms that help them succeed.

2.3 Research Respondents

The research respondents are young entrepreneurs aged 18 to 35. These individuals are actively involved in operating their businesses, with a minimum operational period of six (6) months and a maximum of one (1) year. This demographic is specifically chosen to explore the ethical dilemmas they encounter and the coping mechanisms they employ within the initial stages of their entrepreneurial journey.

Table 1. Shows the Number of Respondents

Respondents (Young Entrepreneur)	Population	Sample	
	F	f	%
Carmen	138	71	36.0%
Buenavista	245	125	64.0%
Total	**383**	**196**	**100%**

A total of 196 participants will be selected using purposive sampling to ensure informative cases and develop a strong understanding. The interview guide will consist of 15 selected participants, and this guide may also provide resources for emotional distress. Using this method, the researchers selected members of the target community who were connected to the study. The participants will complete structured survey questionnaires and an interview guide designed to measure both ethical factors and outcomes. This approach made it easier for researchers to evaluate how ethical dilemmas, such as factors, affect young entrepreneurs.

2.4 Research Instrument

The research instrument consists of a researcher-made questionnaire and interview guide questions. Since it is a researcher-made questionnaire, it will undergo reliability and validity testing to ensure its accuracy and relevance to the study results. The researcher-made questionnaires and interview guide will also undergo pilot testing with a random sample of fifteen (15) 4th year CBM college students and has a business. The instrument, which consists of three parts, is used to collect data. The first part focused on demographic information, while the second part required respondents to rate items on a Likert scale from 4 to 1, featuring closed-ended questions. The last part consisted of guide questions for the interview and a semi-structured interview with open-ended questions to explore variations in the ethical dilemmas faced by young entrepreneurs. The questionnaire is designed to determine the impact of moral dilemmas and coping mechanisms faced by young entrepreneurs.

Part I. Demographic Profile: Presents the demographic profile of the respondents, including age, sex, educational attainment, and business experience; and

Part II. Variables:

A. Ethical Dilemmas. Examine the ethical challenges faced by young entrepreneurs, including Financial Organization Dilemmas, Employee Relationship Dilemmas, Customer Communication Dilemmas, and Acquiescence with Regulatory Values Dilemmas. Our selected respondents will answer this section.

B. Coping Mechanisms. Examine the coping mechanisms used by young entrepreneurs, including Problem-focused Coping and Emotion-focused Coping. Our selected respondents will answer this section.

Table 2. A Guideline for Likert Scale Interpretation in Evaluating the Coping Mechanisms

Scale	Verb al Description	Score Range (Quantitative Value)
4	Strongly Agree	3.25 – 4.00 (High)
3	Agree	2.50 – 3.24(Moderate)
2	Disagree	1.75 – 2.49 (Low)
1	Strongly Disagree	1.00 – 1.74 (Very Low)

DESCRIPTION EQUIVALENCY

- The higher the figure the better the result
- The lower the figure the lower the result

Very Great Extent (VGE) = Strongly Agree (SA)

Great Extent (GE) = Agree (A)

Less Extent (LE) = Moderately Agree (MA)

No Extent (NE) = Disagree (D)

This table guides the interpretation of Likert-scale results for evaluating coping mechanisms used by Young Entrepreneurs. It will use a 4-point rating scale, where a score of 4 ("Strongly Agree") corresponds to a mean range of 3.25 to 4.00, indicating a high level of agreement at the Very Great Extent (VGE) level. A score of 3 "Agree" will fall between 2.50 and 3.24, reflecting moderate agreement as Great Extent (GE). A score of 2 "Disagree" will correspond to a mean range of 1.75 to 2.49, suggesting low agreement as Less Extent (LE). Lastly, a score of 1 ("Strongly Disagree") will be associated with a mean range of 1.00 to 1.74, indicating a very low level of agreement, corresponding to No Extent (NE). This scale will be used to

evaluate the coping mechanisms of the respondents' perceptions regarding the ethical factors influencing their startup business.

Part III. Interview Guide: A structured framework used in qualitative research to guide conversations, consisting of a list of open-ended questions and key topics to cover during an interview. The interview guide encourages detailed responses, outlines themes, and addresses ethical dilemmas. It includes informed consent procedures, privacy strategies, and protocols for handling sensitive information. The interview guide will consist of 15 selected participants and this guide may also provide resources for emotional distress. The structured nature contributes to the research's reliability and integrity.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Protection of Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

The creation of new technologies, methods, or services that would have needed patent protection is not covered by this research. But, to protect the study's unique contribution, it might contain unique components like questionnaires and interviews that are protected by copyright.

B. Informed Consent

Each participant in the study will get an informed consent form detailing the objectives, methods, potential risks, and outcomes of the research. Each respondent stated their understanding of the study and their participation by signing the form. Respondents' privacy and informed consent to participate were protected in this manner.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

To guarantee that no private or sensitive information is compromised, the researchers protect and safeguard the privacy of those who participated in accordance with data privacy laws. All information supplied by the researchers is guaranteed to be securely stored, managed,

and not accessible to unauthorized put in one secured cabinet or box that the researcher only can access. Disposing of instruments, such as shredding and deleting the files, is applied after two years of conducting the research study.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom and Withdrawal

The respondents in this study were volunteers who volunteered to take part. The chosen young entrepreneurs from Buenavista and Carmen are not required to complete the survey if they feel it has harmed them physically or emotionally. Respondents were encouraged to dedicate their time and energy to the study by the voluntary method, which provided them a sense of free will.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

By carefully selecting and ensuring the safety of the survey questionnaires and interviews, as well as by preventing any psychological, physical, or emotional injury, the researchers intended the study to reduce any potential harm to all the respondents. Respondents were made aware of their rights, any hazards, the procedure, and the objective. Support services like expert therapy sessions, emergency hotlines, and prompt aid are available in case of harm or danger. This method maintained ethical norms during the research study while promoting the respondent's well-being.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

The beneficence of the research lies in its potential to improve ethical decision-making, reduce harm, and promote well-being. The contribution to knowledge involves identifying common ethical dilemmas, understanding the effectiveness of different coping mechanisms, and developing interventions to support individuals facing ethical challenges.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

The researchers will select the respondents fairly and transparently, ensuring a fair and free selection process. All came from different backgrounds and levels, promoting a thorough understanding of Ethical Dilemmas and Coping Mechanisms faced by Young Entrepreneurs, specifically those businesses operating between 6 months and 1 year.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

The researchers will use clear and organized methods to ensure accurate and consistent data collection and analysis. To maintain objectivity, access to the data is limited to the researchers. The researchers also considered potential biases and restrictions, including sampling issues or unclear responses, that might have an impact on the findings. To make sure the data is accurate and comprehensive, the researchers politely followed up with respondents who had left portions of the survey incomplete and requested them to fill in the blanks. Expert validation of the survey, mindful processing of incomplete forms, and accurate reporting of all results were done to reduce these concerns. These actions will support ethical norms and strengthen the study's credibility.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The results of this study will be presented in all honesty and transparency, guaranteeing that no information remains out, misunderstood, or changed. All initially issued and copyrighted content is correctly cited and recognized. To improve and enhance information relevant to certain aspects of the current study. All tools will be applied.

J. Use of Patented or Copyright materials

There were no patented materials used in the study. The researchers secured the necessary authorizations and cited all copied material, including related articles.

K. Ethical considerations for Animal and Human Trials

An in-depth knowledge of the study's impacts, advantages, and any risks is required for ethical concerns. Respondents were told by the researchers that there would be no physical risks associated with this study because it only focused on their answers. But if needed, appropriate support services were given. Ethical animal use permission is not necessary because no animals were used. Only human respondents were participants in the study, and relevant ethical frameworks and protocols were in place to guarantee their safety and secure their informed consent.

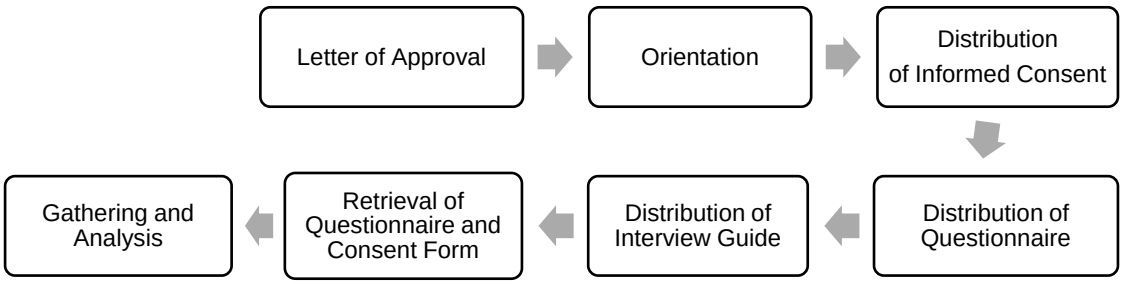
L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technologies

To support the study's grammar and clarity, the researchers use AI tools like Quill Bot and Grammarly. These instruments did not replace the researchers' own evaluations and ideas; instead, they were used as a source of support. All concepts, analyses, and conclusions are thoroughly examined and selected by the researchers. The researchers ensured that the study remained ethical.

M. Ethical Approval

The research will propose ethical approval from the ethics committee and Research and Instructional Innovation Department (RIID) of Saint Michael College of Caraga.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure



With the approval of the relevant authorities, the researcher visited the Department of Trade and Industry offices in Buenavista and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, to obtain necessary information and documents related to the background of young entrepreneurs. These included business lists and other relevant data, which served as primary sources for the study.

Upon receiving consent from the participants, the researcher will personally distribute the survey questionnaires and conduct a physical interview with selected young entrepreneurs. Respondents will be given enough time to complete the forms accurately and honestly. Once accomplished, the questionnaires and the interview guide will be retrieved and prepared for analysis. The responses will then be checked, tallied, and interpreted using appropriate statistical tools.

Letter of Approval. The researcher will submit a formal letter of request to young entrepreneurs to seek validation of the study and obtain permission to proceed with data collection.

Orientation. The researcher will conduct an orientation session for the participants to explain the purpose of the study and ensure that they understand the ethical agreements and the scope of the research.

Distribution of Informed Consent Form. Informed consent forms will be distributed to participants, serving as agreements that confirm they understand their rights and voluntarily agree to participate in the study. Participants will be informed that they may withdraw from the study at any time without any consequences.

Distribution of Questionnaire. The researchers will personally distribute the survey questionnaires to the participants. Sufficient time will be allotted to allow respondents to answer the questions accurately and honestly.

Distribution of Interview Guide. The researchers will perform a physical interview to the participants. Sufficient time will be allotted to allow respondents to answer the questions accurately and honestly.

Retrieval of Questionnaire and Consent Form. After the allotted time, the researcher will personally collect the completed questionnaires and consent forms to prepare for data analysis.

Gathering and Analysis of Data. The data will be collected, checked for completeness, tallied, presented, analyzed, and interpreted using appropriate statistical techniques and tools.

2.7 Data Analysis / Statistical Treatment

Frequency and Percentage - This method will be used to describe the demographic profile of respondents and ethical dilemmas. It will also use to summarize the distribution of responses across our respondents.

Weighted Mean - This tool will be use to determine the score range between ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms.

Pearson's Correlation - This tool will be use to determine the relationship between ethical dilemmas and coping mechanisms.

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Civil Status	:	SINGLE

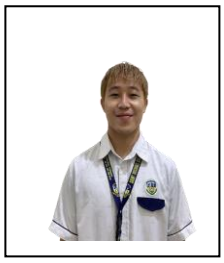
Educational Attainment

Elementary	:	NASIPIT CENTRAL ELEM. SCHOOL
Secondary	:	QUEZON CITY HIGH SCHOOL
Tertiary	:	SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

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Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
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Tertiary	:	SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

Membership/Affiliations

ORGANIZATION	POSITIONS HELD
Junior Financial Executive	**Member**

APPENDICES